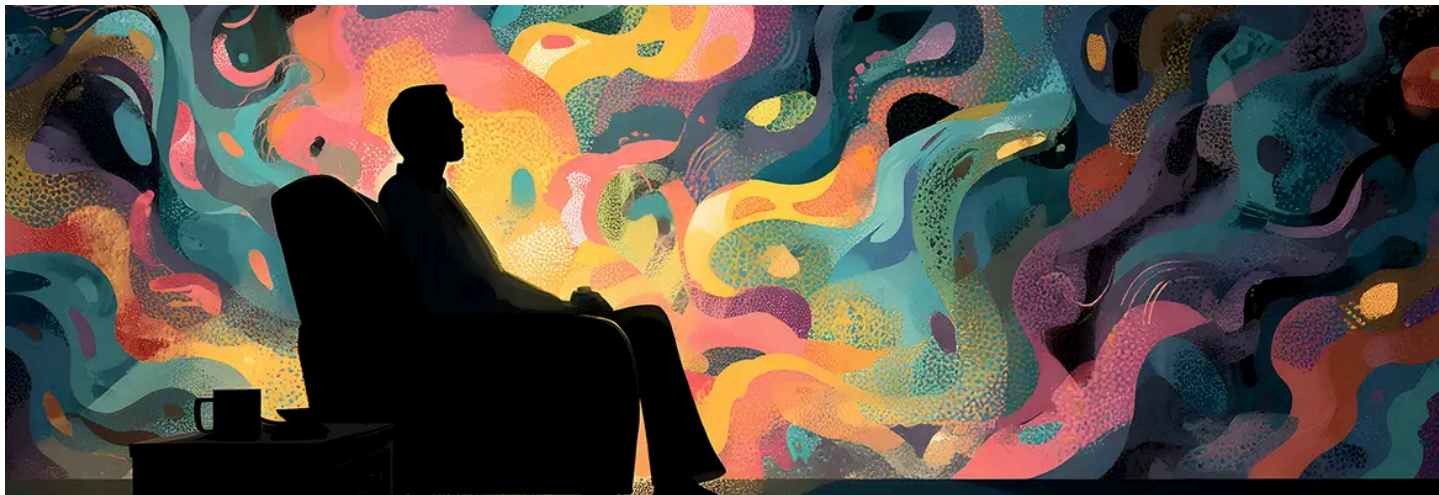


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Reality is a dream not a simulation

Life as a dream is more than metaphor



28th April 2026

↗ cite

Andrew T. Jaffe | Author of *Living the Dream: Cognitive Dream Interface Theory* (Essentia Books, forthcoming).

1,346 words

Read time: approx. 7 mins

*Most physicists are materialists who believe the world consists of physical particles at the fundamental level. Others have argued reality is a simulation or a hallucination of the brain. But **Andrew T. Jaffe** challenges all of these views, proposing an alternative consciousness-first theory where space and time arise as within a dream.*

Most people never stop to consider how bizarre it is to exist at all. We live inside the fact of consciousness so continuously that we rarely examine it. Yet to be alive, aware, and conscious in an apparently material universe is not self-explanatory. It is the deepest mystery we know. We appear here, now, in a world of matter, space, and time, as though such a condition were normal. But perhaps the strange thing is not that [idealism](#) sounds radical. Perhaps the strange thing is that materialism ever felt possible.

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Cognitive Dream Interface Theory, or CDIT, begins from this unease. It asks whether the one thing we know with certainty, awareness itself, should be treated as secondary to the things we only ever know through it. Materialism tells us that consciousness somehow emerges from non-aware matter. Cognitive Dream Interface Theory inverts that order. It proposes that [awareness is primary](#), and that what we call the physical world is a rendered, lawful, and shared appearance within it.

This is where the dream analogy becomes unusually powerful. Many of the central ideas of nondual philosophy are difficult to grasp in the abstract. No self, unreal time, apparent multiplicity, world as appearance: these can sound poetic, obscure, or evasive. But in dreams they become obvious. A dream can generate a world, complete with other people, landscapes, narratives, emotions, and a self who seems to inhabit it. That dream self may have no memory of the waking person in bed. It may be a student again, a stranger, or someone with a wholly different history. Yet when we wake, we immediately see the truth. The dream self was not the true subject. The dream world was not made of matter. The time and space of the dream were not ultimate. A single mind created the whole appearance.

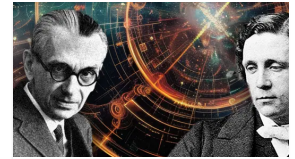
Materialism struggles not only with physics and biology, but with the bare fact of subjectivity.

Cognitive Dream Interface Theory proposes that waking life is not different in kind, only more stable and more coherent. That is why the analogy matters. It does not merely illustrate an idea. It demonstrates a structure.

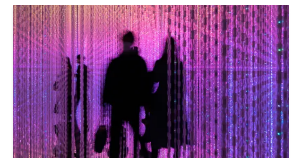
The usual objection is that dreams are private and unstable, while waking reality is lawful and shared. But this distinction strengthens rather than weakens Cognitive Dream Interface Theory. A dream with greater coherence would look more like a world governed by physics. A shared dream would require stable constraints across many viewpoints. In that sense, lawfulness is not evidence against dream-like reality. It is exactly what a rendered experiential world would require.

What is striking is how much of modern science already points in that direction. Gravity is no longer treated as a force in the old mechanical sense, [but as geometry](#). Dark matter is [not directly observed as substance](#), but inferred because, without it, galaxies would not hold together. Dark energy is not seen as an object, but functions as a global condition of expansion. The speed of light is a universal limit on causation

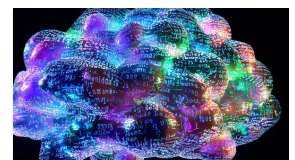
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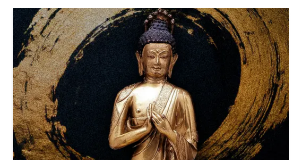


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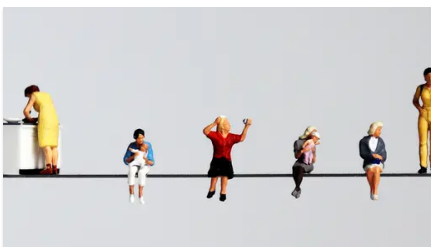


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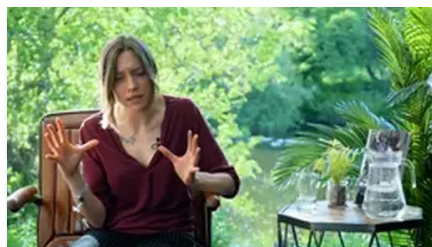


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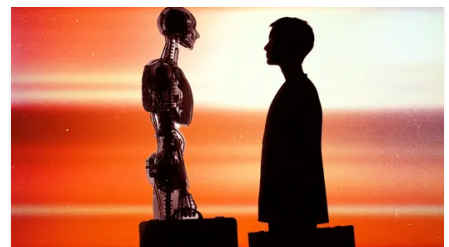
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Noah Naderi 1

28 April 2026

I very much appreciate this article. It really speaks so much to me, since I have always wanted to understand how to conceptualize the Eastern spirituality of how "God dwells within you as you." This really does that. I have thought along these lines for many years now but

didn't know there was a framework already developed upon it, "Cognitive Dream Interface Theory."

Recently I have been getting into Jungian dream analysis, which truly does go along with this. I recommend it for anyone who wants to explore this further.

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